

4 Exploring the new desktop

4.1 New taskbar

The taskbar is the biggest change from all previous versions of Windows including Vista and its one of the best we've seen from Microsoft. It seems like the dock of OS X or Rocket Dock on windows at first, but it works differently and closely integrated with the OS. You can pin any application or folder on the taskbar and it tracks and groups instances of them irrespective of the fact whether they are open or closed.

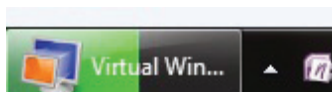


All new taskbar with only icons and no labels

If you multitask a lot, you will be familiar with the problem of too many open windows getting piled up on the desktop and the taskbar. It becomes hard to see what else is underneath or remember what you've already opened.

That's where the taskbar comes in handy. Whenever you open a program, folder, or file, Windows creates a corresponding button on the taskbar showing just an icon that represents the open program.

With the new Progress Bar integrated into the task bar, you can monitor ongoing tasks and processes performed by their applications without having to keep the programs' window visible. The progress of functions including file copies, CD and DVD burning, downloads and installs is displayed dynamically via the Taskbar buttons, through the Progress Bar.



When you move your mouse pointer to a taskbar button, a small picture appears that shows you a miniature version of the corresponding window. This along with Aero Peek, which makes every window on the desktop transparent except the one you're highlighting at the moment, makes sure that you find any window nearly instantly, no matter how many windows your desktop is buried under. To switch to another window, just click on the miniature version that pops out from its taskbar button. You can even close it by middle-clicking, a feature which is common to most applications that use tabbed browsing.